

General Knowledge

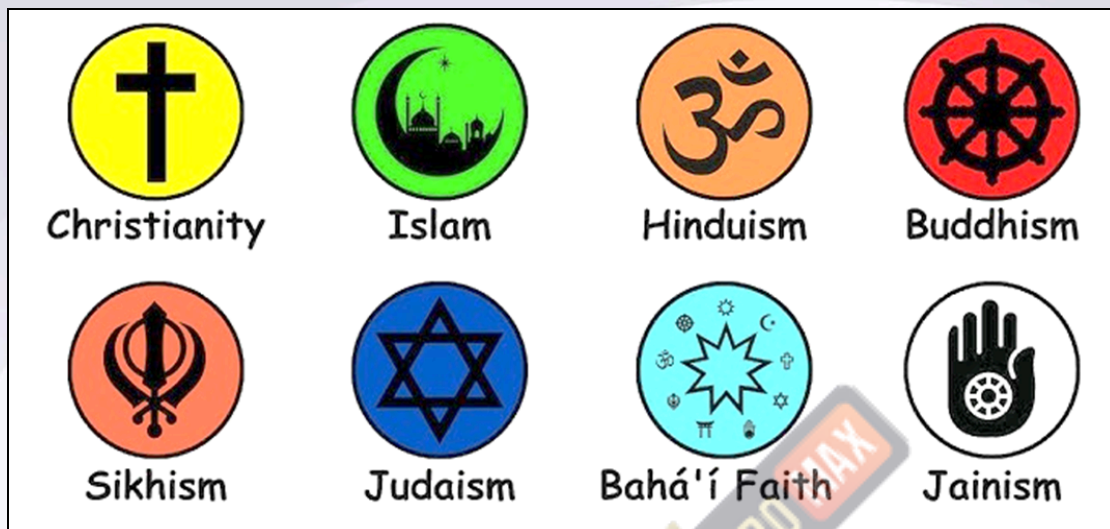
Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Religions in India



RELIGIONS IN INDIA



Introduction to Religion

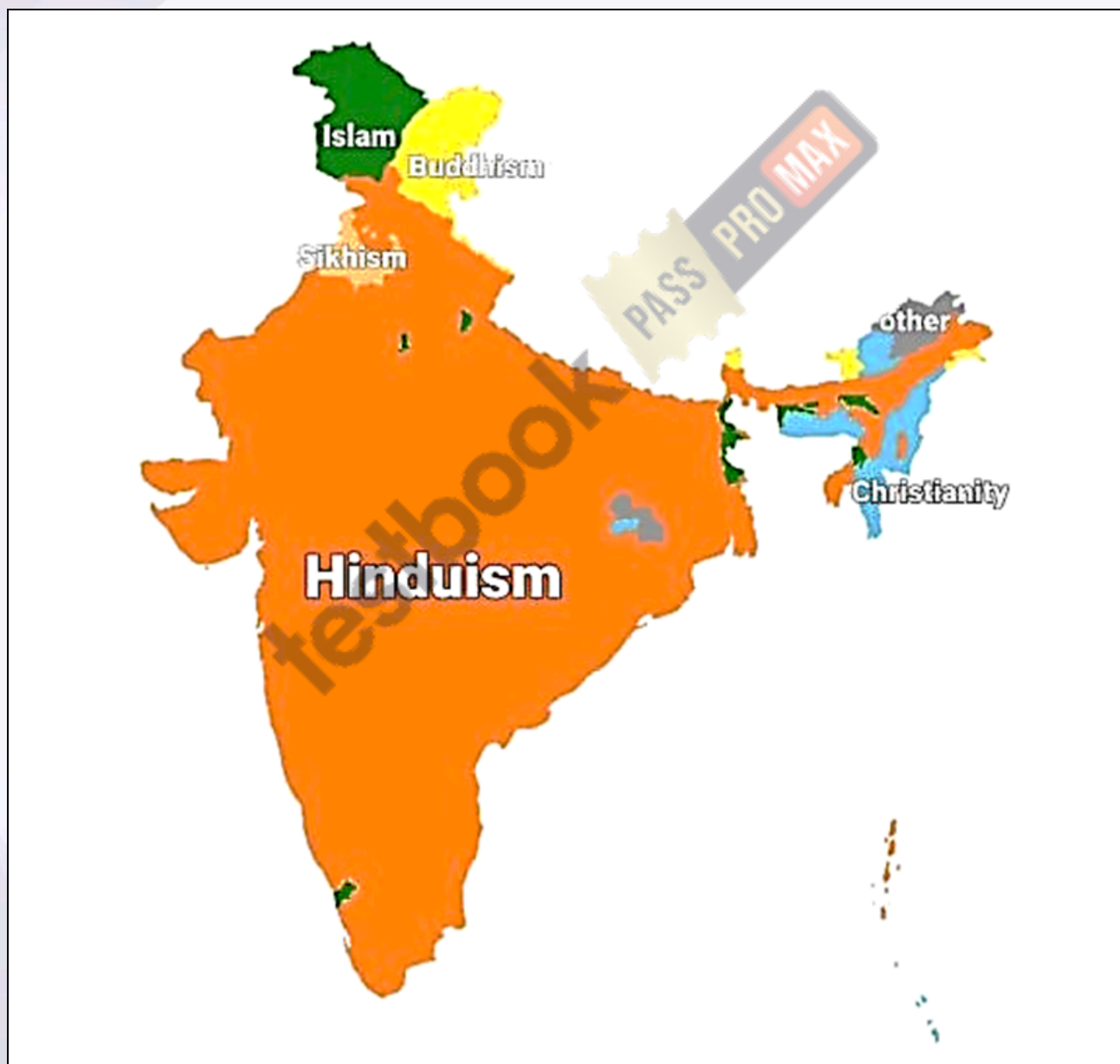
Religion has played a **pivotal role in shaping Indian culture** and social systems throughout history. The **diversity** of religious beliefs and **tolerance** towards all faiths is deeply embedded in Indian society. India is home to **several major religions**, some of which have **originated here**, like **Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism**. These religions, known as **Eastern Religions**, have spread across the world. India also hosts **global religions** like **Islam, Christianity, Zoroastrianism, Judaism, and the Bahai faith**.

Religions in India (2011 Census)

Religion	Percentage (%)	Approximate Population
Hinduism	79.8%	966 million
Islam	14.2%	172 million
Christianity	2.3%	28 million
Sikhism	1.7%	20.8 million

Buddhism	0.7%	8.4 million
Jainism	0.4%	4.5 million
Others* (Zoroastrianism, Judaism, Bahai, tribal religions)	0.9%	~11 million

***Note:** Includes tribal and folk religions.



Major Religions of the World with Followers and Key Countries

Religion	Country (Primary Practice)	Approximate Followers (in millions)
Christianity	USA, Brazil, Europe	2,300
Islam	Indonesia, Saudi Arabia, Pakistan	1,800
Hinduism	India, Nepal	1,100
Buddhism	China, Thailand, Myanmar	500
Sikhism	India, Canada, UK	30
Judaism	Israel, USA	14
Bahai Faith	Iran, India	7
Jainism	India	5
Zoroastrianism	India (Parsis), Iran	0.2

Hinduism

- **Beliefs:** Hinduism is a diverse system of beliefs with multiple gods and practices. It revolves around concepts like **karma (action)**, **dharma (duty)**, and **moksha (liberation)**.
- **Denominations:**
 - **Vaishnavism:** Devotion to Vishnu and his avatars like Rama and Krishna.
 - **Shaivism:** Worship of Shiva as the supreme god.
 - **Shaktism:** Devotion to the divine feminine energy, Shakti or Devi.
 - **Smartism:** Worship of all major gods equally as manifestations of one supreme reality.
- **Scriptures:** Vedas, Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, Ramayana, Mahabharata.

Important Religious Sites – Hinduism

Site	State	Significance
Varanasi	Uttar Pradesh	Oldest living city, sacred to Shiva
Rameswaram	Tamil Nadu	Part of Char Dham, associated with Rama
Puri	Odisha	Home of Jagannath temple and Rath Yatra
Tirupati	Andhra Pradesh	Tirumala Venkateswara Temple
Badrinath	Uttarakhand	Char Dham pilgrimage site
Vaishno Devi	Jammu & Kashmir	Famous shrine in the Trikuta Mountains

Important Festivals – Hinduism

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Diwali	Festival of Lights, celebrating Rama's return to Ayodhya	October/November
Holi	The festival of colours marks the arrival of spring	March
Navratri/Durga Puja	Nine-day festival celebrating Goddess Durga	September/October
Maha Shivratri	Devoted to Lord Shiva	February/March
Janmashtami	Birth of Lord Krishna	August

Islam

- **Beliefs:** Islam teaches the oneness of **Allah** and follows the teachings of **Prophet Muhammad**. It emphasizes submission to God through faith, prayer, fasting, charity, and pilgrimage.
- **Major Sects:**

- **Sunni:** Majority sect, believes in electing caliphs.
- **Shia:** A minority sect, that believes in the divine right of Ali and his descendants.
- **Scripture:** Quran.
- **Five Pillars:** Shahada (faith), Salah (prayer), Zakat (charity), Sawm (fasting), Hajj (pilgrimage).

Important Religious Sites – Islam

Site	State	Significance
Jama Masjid	Delhi	Largest mosque in India
Ajmer Sharif Dargah	Rajasthan	Tomb of Sufi saint Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti
Haji Ali Dargah	Maharashtra	Located on an islet off the coast of Mumbai
Fatehpur Sikri	Uttar Pradesh	Jama Masjid and Sufi tombs

Important Festivals – Islam

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Eid-ul-Fitr	Celebrates the end of Ramadan fasting	Varies (Islamic calendar)
Eid-ul-Adha	Festival of sacrifice	Varies (Islamic calendar)
Muharram	Islamic New Year, commemorates the martyrdom of Imam Hussain	Varies (Islamic calendar)
Shab-e-Barat	Night of forgiveness	Varies (Islamic calendar)

Christianity

- **Beliefs:** Christianity is based on the teachings of **Jesus Christ**, emphasizing love, forgiveness, and salvation.

- **Scripture:** Bible (Old Testament and New Testament).
- **Denominations:**
 - **Catholic:** Follows the Pope's authority.
 - **Protestant:** Reformist sect rejecting the supremacy of the Pope.
 - **Orthodox:** Ancient tradition emphasizing liturgical practices.

Important Religious Sites – Christianity

Site	State	Significance
Basilica of Bom Jesus	Goa	Contains the mortal remains of St. Francis Xavier
St. Thomas Cathedral	Tamil Nadu	Believed to house the tomb of St. Thomas
Sacred Heart Cathedral	Delhi	Prominent church in New Delhi

Important Festivals – Christianity

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Christmas	Birth of Jesus Christ	December 25
Easter	The Resurrection of Jesus Christ	March/April
Good Friday	Commemorates the crucifixion of Jesus	March/April

Sikhism

- **Founded:** By **Guru Nanak** in the 15th century.
- **Beliefs:** Sikhism emphasizes equality, devotion to God, and community service.
- **Text:** Guru Granth Sahib.
- **Symbols:** Five Ks – Kesh (hair), Kangha (comb), Kara (bracelet), Kachera (undergarment), Kirpan (sword).
- **Sacred Sites:** Golden Temple (Amritsar).

Important Religious Sites – Sikhism

Site	State	Significance
Golden Temple	Punjab	Holiest shrine for Sikhs
Anandpur Sahib	Punjab	Birthplace of the Khalsa
Hemkund Sahib	Uttarakhand	Important pilgrimage site

Important Festivals – Sikhism

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Guru Nanak Jayanti	Birth anniversary of Guru Nanak	November
Vaisakhi	Harvest festival and formation of Khalsa	April
Lohri	Winter festival celebrated by Sikhs and Punjabis	January

Buddhism

- **Founded:** By **Gautama Buddha** around 500 BCE.
- **Beliefs:** The Four Noble Truths and the Eightfold Path guide the path to enlightenment (nirvana).
- **Branches:** Theravada and Mahayana.
- **Texts:** Tripitaka (Pali Canon).

Important Religious Sites – Buddhism

Site	State	Significance
Bodh Gaya	Bihar	Place of Buddha's enlightenment
Sarnath	Uttar Pradesh	Buddha's first sermon
Kushinagar	Uttar Pradesh	Buddha's death (Mahaparinirvana)

Important Festivals – Buddhism

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Buddha Purnima	Birth and enlightenment of Buddha	April/May
Losar	Tibetan New Year	February
Ullambana	Ritual for ancestors' liberation	August/September

Jainism

- **Founded:** By **Tirthankaras**, with **Mahavira** being the 24th.
- **Beliefs:** Non-violence (Ahimsa) and renunciation are central to Jain philosophy.
- **Texts:** Agamas.
- **Sects:** Digambara (sky-clad) and Svetambara (white-clad).

Important Religious Sites – Jainism

Site	State	Significance
Palitana Temples	Gujarat	The largest cluster of Jain temples
Ranakpur Temple	Rajasthan	Known for exquisite marble carvings
Shravanabelagola	Karnataka	Home to a massive Gomateshwara statue

Important Festivals – Jainism

Festival	Description	Month/Season
Mahavir Jayanti	Birth anniversary of Mahavira	March/April
Paryushana	Eight-day period of fasting and reflection	August/September
Diwali	Marks the nirvana of Mahavira	October/November